

# Part 0

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## Course Philosophy

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*"The purpose of education is not merely to transmit existing knowledge, but to prepare students to create the knowledge required for the future."*

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## Why This Course Exists

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Artificial intelligence represents one of the most significant technological transformations in modern economic history. Like the Industrial Revolution, electrification, the internet, and cloud computing before it, AI is fundamentally changing how organizations compete, create value, organize work, innovate, and make strategic decisions.

Every major technological revolution has reshaped management.

Artificial intelligence is no exception.

Yet while organizations have changed dramatically, the theoretical foundations of strategic management have evolved more slowly.

For more than fifty years, strategic management has provided managers with frameworks for understanding competition, competitive advantage, organizational capabilities, industry structure, innovation, and long-term value creation. These theories have profoundly influenced managerial practice and remain among the most important intellectual contributions in business scholarship.

Concepts such as:

- Competitive Positioning
- Industry Analysis
- The Resource-Based View
- Dynamic Capabilities
- Organizational Learning
- Core Competencies
- Transaction Cost Economics
- The Knowledge-Based View of the Firm
- Strategic Leadership

continue to explain why some organizations consistently outperform others.

These theories remain essential.

However, many were developed during a period in which organizations operated under assumptions fundamentally different from those that characterize today's AI-enabled economy.

Managers no longer make decisions using only human expertise.

Knowledge is no longer created exclusively by people.

Competitive advantage increasingly depends upon data, algorithms, digital platforms, intelligent automation, and human–AI collaboration.

Information that once required weeks to collect can now be synthesized within minutes.

Experimentation that once required significant financial investment can often be simulated computationally.

Decision support systems increasingly generate recommendations once reserved for experienced managers and consultants.

Artificial intelligence therefore changes not only how organizations execute strategy—it challenges many assumptions about how strategy itself should be understood.

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## The Central Question

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This course is organized around a single question.

**How should strategic management evolve in the age of artificial intelligence?**

This question intentionally differs from those typically asked in strategic management courses.

Traditional strategy courses ask:

- How do firms create competitive advantage?
- Why do some firms outperform others?
- How should managers formulate strategy?

These remain important questions.

This course asks an additional question.

**If the foundational theories of strategic management were written today, in a world shaped by artificial intelligence, what would they look like?**

Throughout the semester students will revisit this question from multiple theoretical perspectives.

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## Beyond Learning Frameworks

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Many courses teach strategic frameworks.

Students memorize Porter's Five Forces.

Students memorize VRIO.

Students memorize Dynamic Capabilities.

Students memorize Organizational Learning.

Unfortunately, memorization is not strategic thinking.

Strategic thinking requires questioning assumptions.

It requires recognizing when a framework continues to explain organizational reality and when changing technologies require new explanations.

Artificial intelligence provides an opportunity to revisit many of the foundational assumptions that have guided strategic management for decades.

This course therefore emphasizes interpretation rather than memorization.

Students are expected to understand why theories emerged, evaluate their assumptions, identify their limitations, and propose how they should evolve.

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## Artificial Intelligence Is Not the Subject

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At first glance, this course appears to be about artificial intelligence.

It is not.

Artificial intelligence provides the context.

The true subject of this course is strategic management.

Artificial intelligence serves as the catalyst that encourages us to reconsider how organizations compete, innovate, learn, govern, and create value.

Students will therefore spend as much time reading Porter, Barney, Teece, Grant, March, Prahalad, Hamel, Wernerfelt, Williamson, and Eisenhardt as they do reading contemporary AI scholarship.

The objective is not to replace classical theory.

The objective is to reinterpret classical theory.

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## A Dialogue Between Two Literatures

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One distinguishing feature of this curriculum is the deliberate pairing of foundational strategic management scholarship with contemporary research on artificial intelligence.

Each week students engage in a scholarly dialogue between two bodies of literature.

The first asks:

Why do organizations succeed?

The second asks:

How does artificial intelligence change the answer?

Neither literature is complete without the other.

Classical theory provides intellectual foundations.

AI research provides contemporary context.

Together they encourage students to reconsider the future of strategic management.

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## From Student to Scholar

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This course assumes that graduate education should extend beyond mastering existing knowledge.

Students are invited to participate in the continuing evolution of strategic management.

Every week concludes with a Theory Evolution Exercise in which students respond to a single prompt:

**If I were rewriting this theory in 2026, I would...**

Students identify assumptions embedded within classical theories, evaluate how artificial intelligence reinforces or challenges those assumptions, and propose theoretically grounded revisions.

By the conclusion of the semester these reflections become an original scholarly manuscript:

### **Toward a Theory of Strategic Management in the Age of Artificial Intelligence**

Rather than simply consuming scholarship, students begin contributing to it.

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## Learning Like a Strategy Consultant

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Throughout the semester students adopt the perspective of a strategy consultant rather than that of a passive learner.

Organizations rarely present clearly defined problems.

Executives rarely possess complete information.

Technological change creates ambiguity rather than certainty.

Consequently, students repeatedly analyze organizations, evaluate competing strategic alternatives, justify recommendations with evidence, defend decisions before executive audiences, and revise their thinking as new information emerges.

This mirrors professional strategic practice.

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## Artificial Intelligence as a Thinking Partner

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Artificial intelligence is treated throughout this course as a thinking partner rather than an answer generator.

Students are encouraged to use AI to:

- explore ideas,
- compare theories,
- critique arguments,
- summarize literature,
- develop alternative perspectives,
- improve communication,
- and support strategic analysis.

However, AI never replaces professional judgment.

Every recommendation submitted during this course ultimately represents the responsibility of the student.

Learning to work effectively with AI therefore requires skepticism, verification, reflection, and intellectual humility.

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## Responsible Strategic Leadership

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Organizations exist within broader economic, legal, political, technological, and social systems.

Artificial intelligence amplifies both opportunity and responsibility.

Strategic leaders must therefore balance:

- innovation,
- competitive advantage,
- governance,
- ethics,
- stakeholder interests,
- sustainability,
- organizational performance,
- and long-term societal impact.

Throughout this course these issues are treated as integral components of strategic management rather than separate discussions of technology ethics.

Responsible leadership is not an elective topic.

It is a core strategic capability.

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## The Vision of This Course

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The ambition of this curriculum extends beyond preparing students to use artificial intelligence.

Its purpose is to prepare strategic leaders capable of guiding organizations through profound technological transformation.

By the conclusion of the semester students should possess:

- a deep understanding of classical strategic management,
- familiarity with the emerging scholarship on AI and organizations,
- the ability to critically evaluate strategic theory,
- practical experience applying AI to executive decision making,
- and the confidence to contribute to the future development of strategic management itself.

Ultimately, this course asks students to do more than learn strategy.

It asks them to participate in the continuing evolution of one of management's most important disciplines.

That is both the challenge and the opportunity of studying strategic management in the age of artificial intelligence.